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NEWSPAPER

4th September, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

36th WEEK



ROHINGYAS & AUNG SAN SUU KYI

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II... INDIA AND ITS NEIGHBORHOOD- RELATIONS.

UPSC CSE – GS III

**GS III... SECURITY CHALLENGES AND THEIR MANAGEMENT IN
BORDER AREAS.**



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EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

4th SEPTEMBER, 2017

Perform or perish

A Cabinet reshuffle that was unusually free from political considerations

For a change, performance, and not political expedience, seems to have dictated the nature and extent of the shuffle in the Council of Ministers. A few of the poor performers have been shown the door, notably Ministers of State Bandaru Dattatreya and Rajiv Pratap Rudy, and some of the better performers among the Ministers of State have been elevated to Cabinet rank, including Nirmala Sitharaman, Piyush Goyal and Dharmendra Pradhan. Kalraj Mishra probably lost out because of the age factor, an indication that Prime Minister Narendra Modi is serious about the 75-year-rule. Four of the entrants are former civil servants, and two of them, Hardeep Singh Puri and Alphons Kannantharam, are not even MPs. As Ministers with independent charge, their mandate will be to single-mindedly focus on results without having to worry about nurturing a constituency or reporting to a career politician. After her eventful stint in the Commerce Ministry, Ms. Sitharaman was rewarded with the Defence Ministry, making her only the second woman after Indira Gandhi to hold the portfolio. But the choices are also an indication of the small talent pool before Mr. Modi. At the time he was sworn in, he included in his team Arun Jaitley and Smriti Irani despite their having lost in the Lok Sabha election. Manohar Parrikar was asked to resign as Chief Minister of Goa to assume responsibility as Defence Minister, only to be sent back after the BJP all but lost Goa in the Assembly election this year. V.K. Singh, a former Army Chief who joined the BJP just before he was given the party ticket, was made Minister of State for External Affairs. Suresh Prabhu, who was sidelined in the Shiv Sena, was persuaded to join the BJP and given the important portfolio of Railways. And now, despite his offer to resign after a series of rail accidents, he was asked to wait and then made Minister for Commerce and Industry.

Of course, it will be far from the truth to say that nothing but performance has mattered. Ms. Irani, who was moved out of the Human Resource Development Ministry after a string of controversies, retains the key Information and Broadcasting portfolio. Uma Bharti was divested of her pet portfolio of River Development and Ganga Rejuvenation but got Drinking Water and Sanitation instead. The mercurial Ms. Bharti would have been a difficult person to keep out, and the change of portfolios is a political compromise. However, by choosing to ignore the claims of the BJP's allies, and by making no attempt to correct imbalances in regional representation, Mr. Modi succeeded in creating the impression that he had nothing in mind other than picking the best person for each job. In neglecting political claims he actually sent the political signal he wanted to: that he is his own man and that he will have the team he wants.



Performance, not the political considerations seems to be the criteria



Kenyan Supreme Court annulled the Presidential polls asking for re-elections

Back to the ballot

With the Kenyan presidential vote annulled, the election body must fix processes quickly

The Kenyan Supreme Court's annulment of the presidential vote is a bitter-sweet victory for an ethnically divided country exasperated by the brutal violence that has marred successive polls. Friday's decision is a challenge to the election commission, which needs to repair its tarnished reputation. It is also a challenge to the political parties, which need to find a dignified way of settling election disputes. President Uhuru Kenyatta's opponent, Raila Odinga, a three-time contender, alleged that the integrity of the polls was compromised during the cumbersome data transformation process, from ballot boxes to computers. The violence that followed the declaration of the results exacerbated tribal divisions, and left at least 20 people dead. It was not of the order of the post-poll violence in 2007, when more than 1,000 people were killed and for which several politicians faced trial at the International Criminal Court for alleged crimes against humanity. The 2013 campaign, held under a new constitution, was equally chaotic and controversial and the final verdict was challenged by Mr. Odinga. Despite an overhaul of the poll mechanism, this year there was increased scepticism over the prospects for free and fair polls following the murder of a top official from the electoral body. Given the absence of the institutional prerequisites of a functioning modern democracy, there is the real danger of a steady erosion of popular legitimacy for any form of representative government. But there is a positive dimension to Kenyan politics. Governments have deferred to the principle of periodic renewal of the popular mandate ever since the country returned to multi-party democracy in the 1990s. This is in stark contrast to the practice in some African nations where incumbents resort to constitutional fiat to stay in office almost indefinitely.

For all these reasons, the Kenyan court's decision for a repeat election appeals to common sense, despite its characterisation by some as relatively peaceful. The rerun, to be held within 60 days, is of course bound to raise genuine doubts about the efficacy of the electoral mechanism to undertake another mammoth and expensive operation, with no guarantee of a clear result. Mr. Odinga's supporters are naturally enthused about another chance at the hustings; but there would be few takers for any more outcries of foul play, whatever the outcome. In an assertion of judicial independence, the court has taken a calculated gamble on the country's democratic future. Politics should commensurately evolve to a level of accountability where the habit of exploiting traditional loyalties gives way to respect for human rights and observance of the rule of law. Kenya is in the midst of a prolonged drought, and many face the risk of starvation. Kenyans need, above all, a stable government committed to mitigating their sufferings.

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A blind eye

Myanmar's refusal to address the Rohingya issue diminishes its democratic transition

The continuing failure of the Myanmar government to act decisively and urgently to protect civilians from the raging crossfire between the security forces and insurgents is shocking. The recent clashes in the western State of Rakhine have claimed over 70 lives and forced thousands of Rohingyas to flee across the border into Bangladesh, in a rapidly deteriorating humanitarian crisis. Most of the victims are women and children, according to the UN's International Organisation for Migration, which has called for additional aid to cope with Dhaka's refugee situation. The latest flare-up began last Friday when militants suspected to be from the Arakan Rohingya Salvation Army attacked military and police outposts. That should have served as a caution against an excessive counter-insurgency operation, a real possibility given the history of systematic persecution of the Muslim minorities in Rakhine. The military crackdown that followed has been widely condemned as disproportionate and the government accused of being an onlooker. The UN High Commissioner for Human Rights has even rebuked Aung San Suu Kyi's office for what he described as irresponsible statements that could disrupt aid and relief activity. Ms. Suu Kyi is not just the foreign minister; as a Nobel peace prize winner she has also failed to exert any moral pressure to secure humane treatment and humanitarian assistance for the systematically persecuted Rohingyas. She has rightly come under criticism for her continued silence over the army brutalities.

In fact, the UN agency's report in February, based on a study of the military crackdown, had described the slaughter of thousands and displacement of even larger numbers as crimes against humanity. But the reactions of the radical Buddhist nationalists, who have traditionally resisted recognition of the Rohingyas as citizens of Myanmar, have been predictable. They have demanded even tougher action from the government in the wake of the terror unleashed over the past week, and rubbished the findings of the officially appointed Advisory Commission on Rakhine State, headed by former UN Secretary General Kofi Annan. The Myanmar government has an obligation to act on the recommendations of the Commission, on the guarantee of citizenship rights to the Rohingyas, freedom of movement and enforcement of the rule of law. It is inconceivable that the country's yearning for peace and normal life could be fulfilled in the absence of these minimum prerequisites. The ruling National League for Democracy, which takes legitimate pride in its heroic defiance of the military junta, has a largely unfinished agenda on democratic transition. Enormous powers are vested in the military. The further consolidation of the hard-won freedoms from dictatorship will remain an arduous task so long as a large minority of the population is systematically excluded from the political process.

INDIA

NEPAL

BANGLADESH

Myanmar
(Burma)

VIETNAM

Lao PDR

Rakhine

THAILAND

CAMBODIA

Bay of Bengal

Gulf



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MYANMAR



FACT FILE ON MYANMAR

- *Region* ... SE Asia
- *Population* ... 53 million
- *Religion* ... Buddhism
- *Capital* ... Naypyidaw
- *Currency* ... Burmese kyat

1 The Constitution was drafted by the military

2 Article 59F says anyone with foreign children is ineligible to become President

3 25% of the seats in Parliament reserved for military (unelected armed forces)

4 Commander-in-Chief will nominate the heads of three powerful Ministries viz., Home Affairs, Defence & Border Affairs.

WHO ARE ROHINGYAS?

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FACTUAL INFORMATION



- 1 Rohingyas belong to Muslim sect.
- 2 They are one of Myanmar's many ethnic minorities.
- 3 Rohingyas say that they are descendants of Arab traders who have been in the region for generations.
- 4 Myanmar Government sees them as illegal immigrants from Bangladesh.
- 5 The Country also denies them the citizenship as per the Citizenship Law 1982.
- 6 Myanmar is predominantly Buddhist country.
- 7 It has a long history of communal mistrust.
- 8 The country has been under the Military rule for several years and this mistrust is exploited by the army.

WHAT IS THE RECENT ORIGIN OF CLASHES?



- 1 Recently, militants suspected to be from the Arakan Rohingya Salvation Army attacked military and police outposts.
- 2 The military crackdown that followed has been widely condemned as disproportionate.
- 3 The Govt. is accused of being the on-looker.



WHAT THE WORLD COMMUNITY IS DOING?



International Organisation for Migration has called for additional aid to cope with Dhaka's refugee situation. Thousands of people are migrating to Bangladesh.

- 1** United Nations Human Rights Office stated that abuses suffered by them would amount to crimes against humanity. The UN High Commissioner for Human Rights has even rebuked Aung San Suu Kyi's Office.
- 2** The International press is not allowed to visit these areas so as to look at the alleged abuses on Rohingyas.
- 3** 10 member ASEAN has got cardinal rule of not criticizing each other about their internal affairs.
- 4** However Indonesia, Malaysia expressed their protest in feeble voices.

AUNG SAN SUU KYI ... SILENCE

She rightly came under criticism for her continued silence over the army brutalities.

- 1** Aung San Suu Kyi is not just the Foreign Minister, she is the Nobel Prize winner.
- 2** She failed to accept any moral pressure, secure humane treatment and humanitarian assistance for the systematically persecuted Rohingyas.
- 3** The ruling National League for Democracy, which takes legitimate pride in the heroic defiance of the military junta is not doing much.

However, enormous powers are vested with the military.

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